



MARGARET
WILD
RON BROOKS







Dog and Magpie are friends

but when Fox comes into the bush, everything changes.

Fox is an archetypal drama about friendship, loyalty, risk and betrayal—a story that is as rich for adults as for children.

- Children's Book Council of Australia Picture Book of the Year, 2001
- NSW Premier's Literary Awards, Patricia Wrightson Prize, 2001
- Queensland Premier's Literary Awards, Best Children's Book, 2001
- APA Design Awards, Scholastic Australia Best-designed Children's Picture Book, 2001
- Kate Greenaway Medal, shortlisted, 2000
- IBBY Honour List, 2002
- Deutscher Jugendliteraturpreis, 2004
- IBBY Winner, 2006
- Japan School Library Association, Best Translated Picture Book, 2001

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ROBIN MORROW, *Australian Bookseller & Publisher*

*'a masterpiece that leaves no reader untouched, whatever their age . . .
alive and immediate, pulsing with the emotions that are its lifeblood,
heart-strong with the impulses and talents of its creators'*

LINNET HUNTER, *Magpies*

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beautiful picture book this year'*

JANE DOONAN, *School Librarian*

*'an incredible book with the shattering power of the best fables . . .
beautiful, wild and tragic'*

TARA STEPHENSON, *The Bookseller*

'one of the all-time greats'

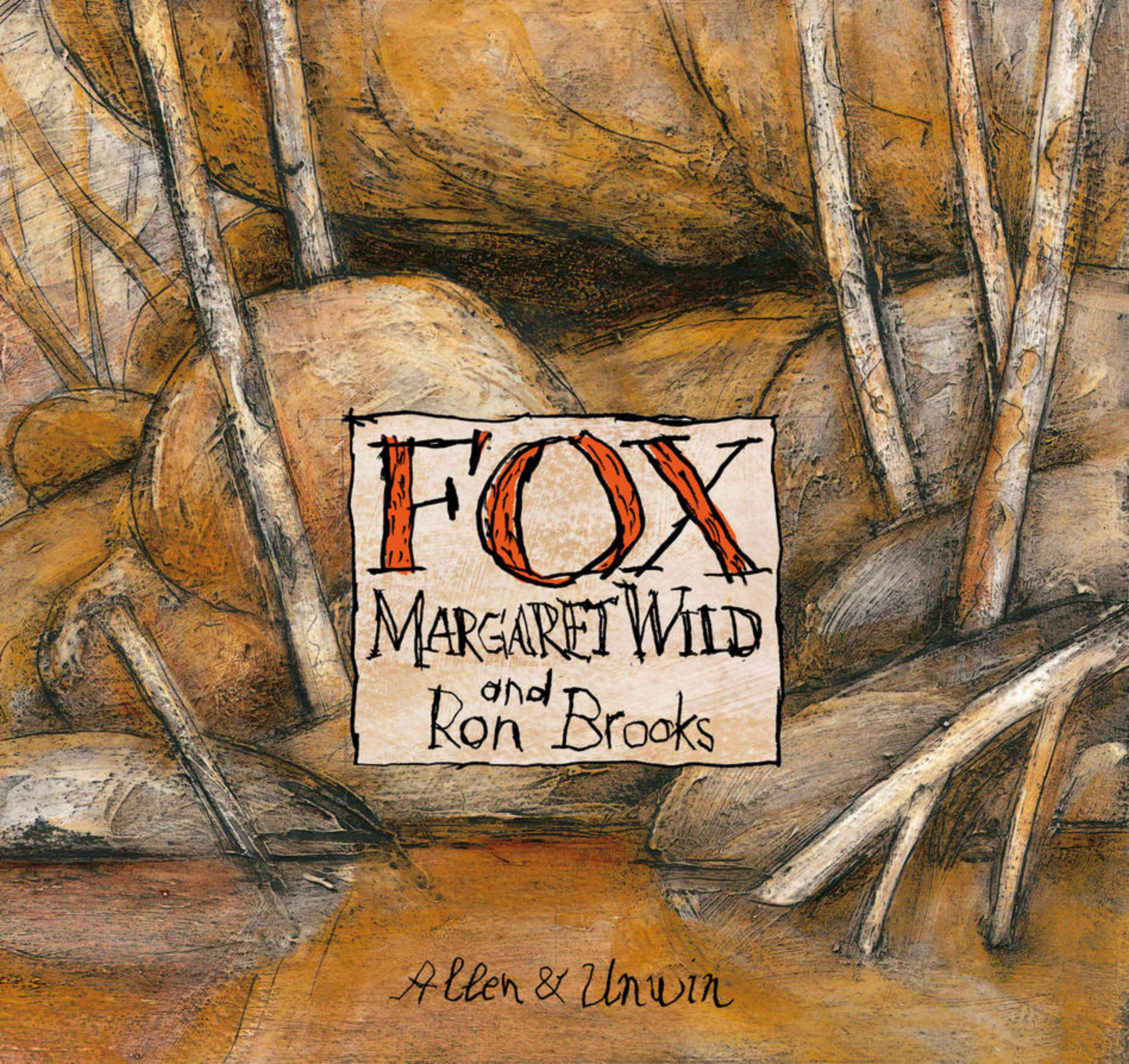
MOIRA ROBINSON, *Magpies*

*'This shattering collision of paint and prose has pictures so epic and vivid they make
you weep, and words so stark and poignant they knock you out of your boots'*

ANGUS FONTAINE, *Australian Style*







FOX

MARGARET WILD
and
Ron Brooks

Allen & Unwin

FOR Row, Rosalind and Sarah,
With thanks. M.W.

To M.W. for the words
and to Margaret, for the waiting. R.B.



THROUGH THE CHARRED FOREST,
OVER HOT ASH, RUNS DOG, with a bird
clamped in his big, gentle mouth.
He takes her to his cave above the river,
and there he tries to tend her burnt wing.

but Magpie does not want
his help.

"I will never again be able to fly,"
she whispers.

"I know," says Dog.

He is silent for a moment, then he says,

"I am blind in one eye,
but life is still good."

"An eye is nothing!" says Magpie.
"How would you feel if you
couldn't run?"

Dog does not answer.

Magpie drags her body
into the shadow of the rocks,
until she feels herself
melting into blackness.



DAYS, perhaps a week later, she WAKES with a rush of grief. Dog is waiting. He persuades her to go with him to the riverbank.

"Hop on my back,"
he says. "Look into the
water and tell me
what you see."

Sighing, Magpie does as he asks.
Reflected in the water are clouds and sky
and trees — and something else.

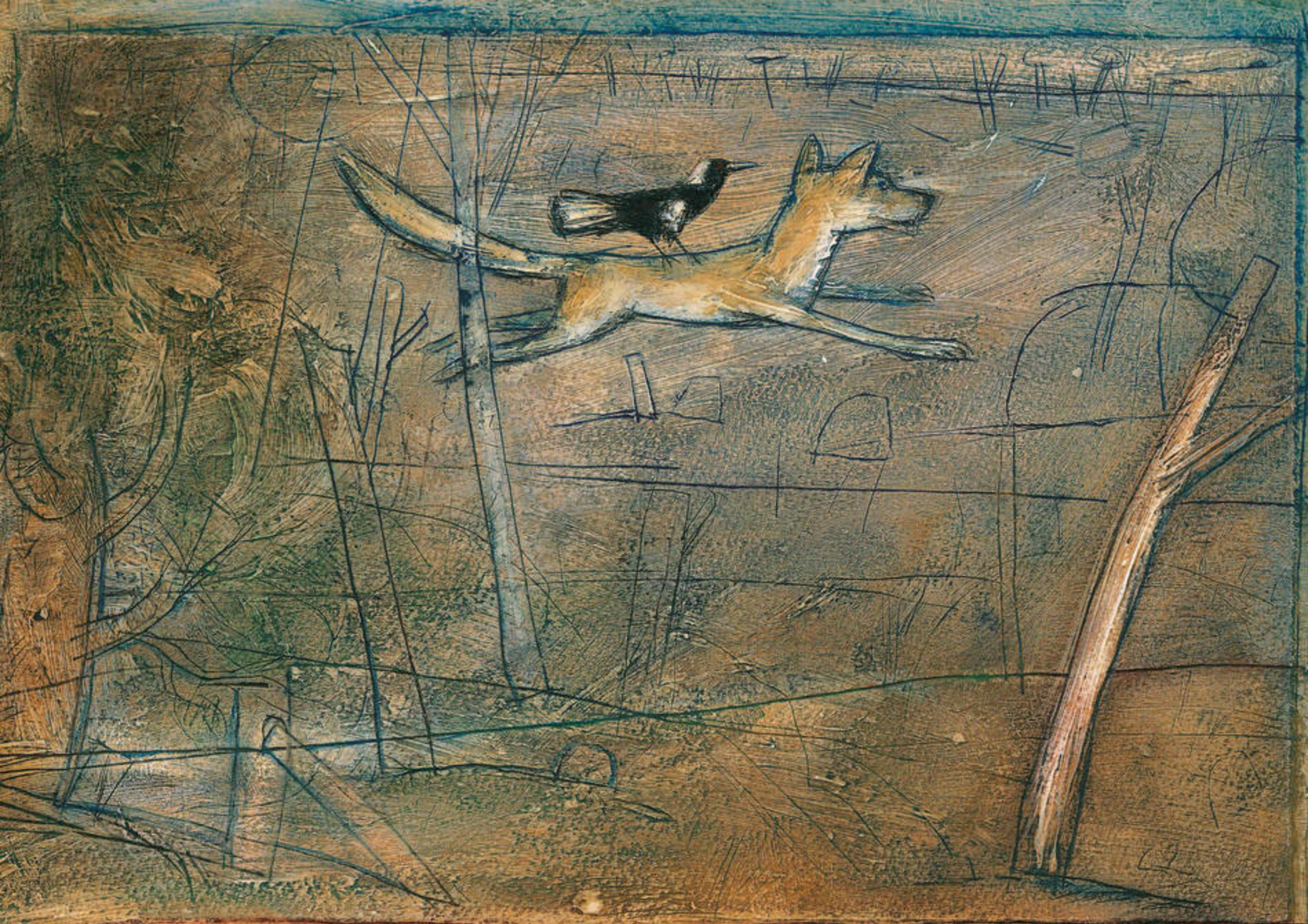
"I see a strange new creature!" she says.



"That is us," says Dog. "Now hold on tight!"

With Magpie clinging to his back, he races through the scrub,
past the stringybarks, past the clumps of yellow box trees,
and into blueness. He runs so swiftly,
it is almost as if he were flying.



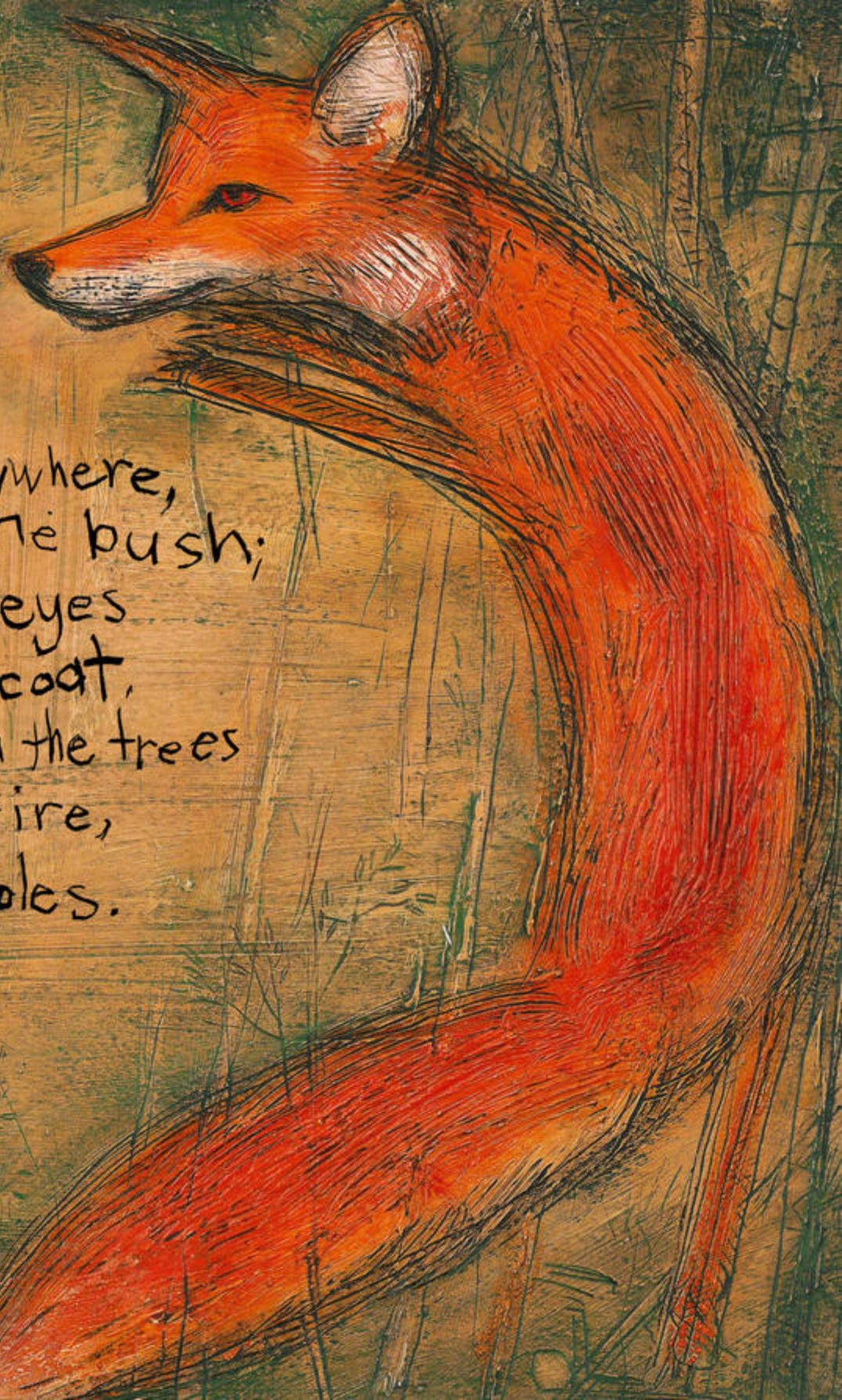


Magpie feels the wind streaming through her feathers,
and she rejoices. "FLY, Dog, FLY! I will be
your missing eye, and you will be my wings."



And so Dog runs, with Magpie
on his back, every day,
through Summer, through Winter.

After the rains,
when saplings are
springing up everywhere,
a fox comes into the bush;
Fox with his haunted eyes
and rich red coat,
He flickers through the trees
like a tongue of fire,
and Magpie trembles.

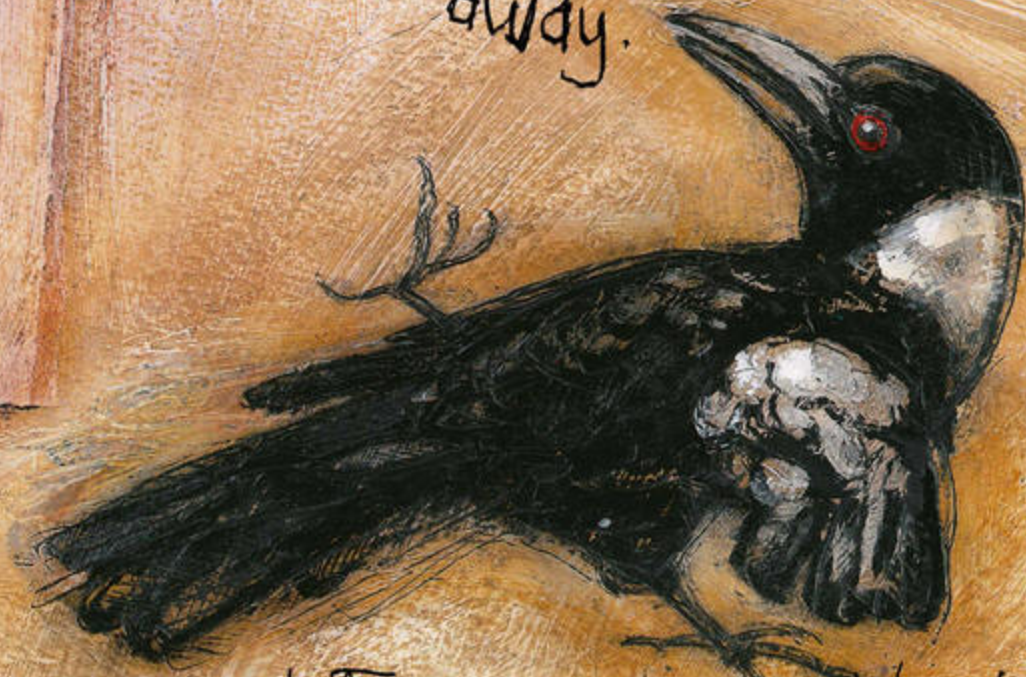


But Dog says, "Welcome.
We can offer you food
and shelter."



"Thank you," says Fox.
"I saw you running this morning.
You looked extraordinary."

Dog beams,
but Magpie
shrinks
away.



She can feel Fox staring at her burnt wing.

In the evenings, when the air is creamy with blossom,
Dog and Magpie relax at the mouth of the cave,
enjoying each other's company.

Now and again Fox joins in the conversation,
but Magpie can feel him watching,
always watching her.



And at night his smell seems to fill the cave—
a smell of rage and envy and loneliness.





Magpie tries to warn Dog about Fox.
"He belongs nowhere," she says. "He loves no one."
But Dog says, "He's all right. Let him be."

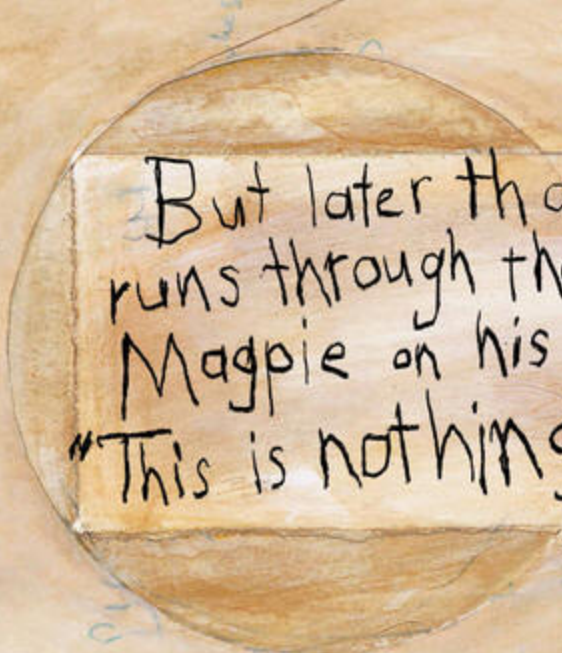


That night, when Dog is asleep, Fox whispers to Magpie,
"I can run faster than Dog. Faster than the wind.
Leave Dog and come with me."

Magpie says, "I will never leave Dog. I am his
missing eye and he is my wings."

Fox says no more that night,
but the next day when Dog is at the river,
he whispers to Magpie, "Do you
remember what it is like to fly?"
Truly fly?"

Again Magpie says, "I will never leave Dog.
I am his missing eye
and he is my wings."



But later that day, as Dog
runs through the scrub with
Magpie on his back, she thinks,
"This is nothing like flying.
Nothing!"



And when at dawn
Fox whispers to her
for the third time,
she whispers back,
"I am ready."





While Dog sleeps, Magpie and Fox streak past
coolibah trees, rip through long grass, pelt over rocks.

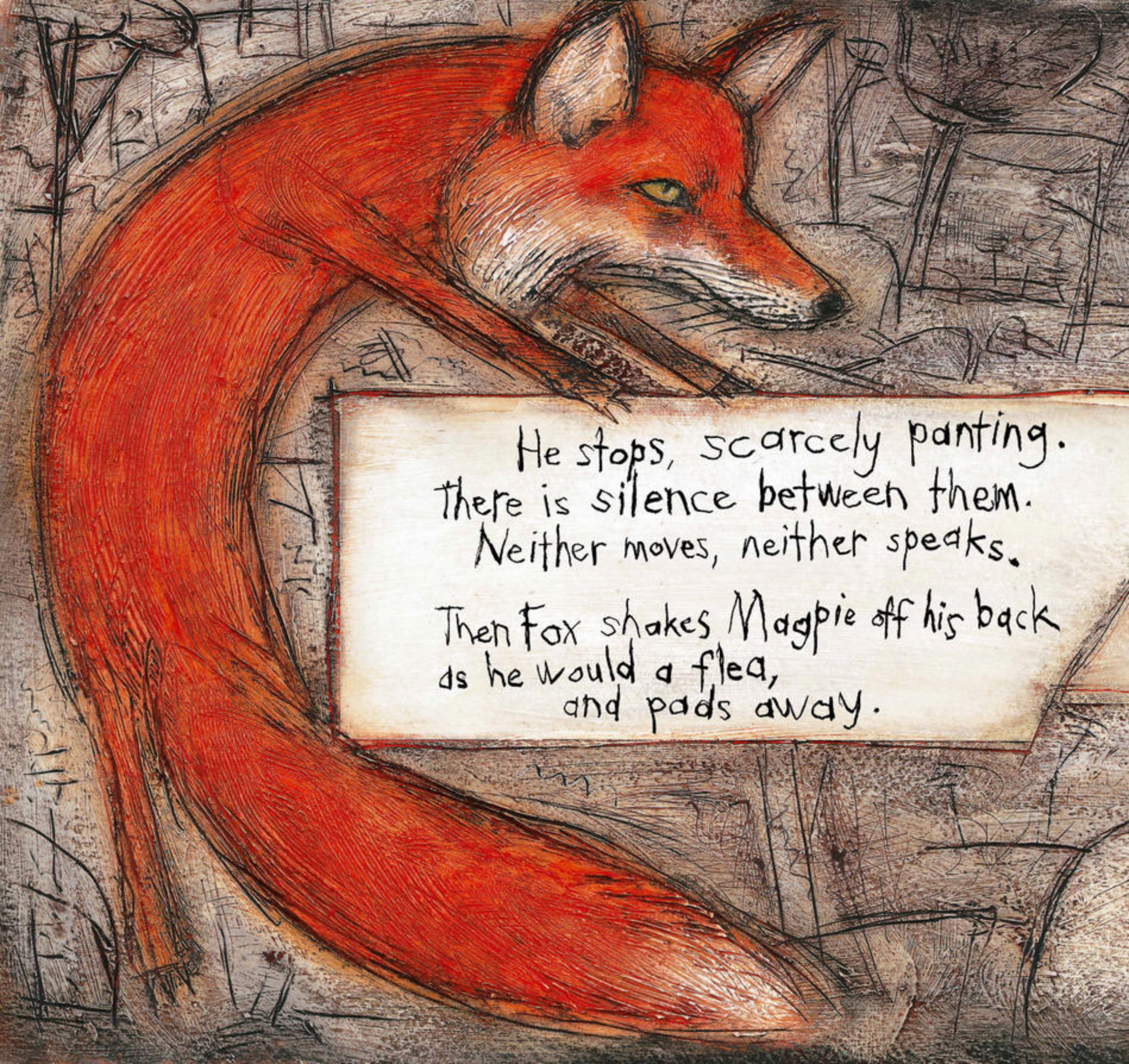


Fox runs so fast that his feet scarcely touch the ground,
and Magpie exults, "At last I am flying, Really flying!"¹¹

The painting depicts a desert scene. The upper half is a vast, textured expanse of red and orange, representing the sky or a distant desert plain. A single, dark, gnarled tree stands in the middle ground, its branches reaching upwards. Below the tree, a light-colored, curved path or road leads from the foreground towards the horizon. The foreground is filled with dark, green, and brown brushstrokes, suggesting dense, scrubby vegetation. The overall style is expressive and painterly, with visible brushwork throughout.

Fox scorches through woodlands,
through dusty plains, through salt pans,
and out into the hot red desert.



A detailed illustration of a red fox in a forest. The fox is shown in profile, facing right, with its head slightly lowered. Its fur is a vibrant red, and its eyes are a pale yellow. The fox's long tail is visible, curving downwards. The background is a dark, textured forest scene with various shades of brown and grey, suggesting trees and foliage. The overall style is painterly and somewhat somber.

He stops, scarcely panting.
There is silence between them.
Neither moves, neither speaks.
Then Fox shakes Magpie off his back
as he would a flea,
and pads away.

He turns and looks at Magpie, and he says,
"Now you and Dog will know what it is like
to be truly alone."

Then he is gone.
In the stillness, Magpie hears a faraway scream.
She cannot tell if it is a scream of triumph
or despair.







Magpie huddles, a scruff of feathers adrift in heat.
She can feel herself burning into nothingness.
It would be so easy just to die here in the desert.

But then she thinks of Dog waking to find her gone.





Slowly, jiggety-hop,
she begins the long journey home.

Margaret Wild and Ron Brooks have created
three exceptional picture books together, *Old Pig*,
Rosie and Tortoise and the multi-award-winning *Fox*,
published in twelve countries around the world.

Margaret Wild has written a range of remarkable books,
including the novels *Jinx* and *One Night*, and the picture
books *The Very Best of Friends*, *First Day*, *Nighty Night!*
and *Baby Boomsticks*.

Ron Brooks is acclaimed as the maker of many well-loved
picture books, which include *The Bunyip of Berkeley's Creek*,
John Brown, *Rose and the Midnight Cat*, *Motor Bill* and
the Lovely Caroline, *Henry's Bed* and *Henry's Bath*.

Margaret lives in Sydney, New South Wales.

Ron lives in Huonville, Tasmania.



